

MANDAL COMMISSION

Harvest of Shame

It was a decision that will live for ever in infamy and become the benchmark of the descent of Prime Minister Vishwanath Pratap Singh from leader to demagogue. His announcement on August 7—two days before Devi Lal's kisan rally in New Delhi—that the Government would implement recommendations of the Mandal Commission, was initially greeted as a master-stroke calculated to consolidate the backward castes as the new vote bank of the badly mauled Janata Dal. That Singh was willy-nilly planting the



REBEL WITH A CAUSE: Goswami in 1990

seeds for a new political harvest became evident when he used the Red Fort as an electoral platform on Independence Day to reiterate his commitment to implement the commission's recommendations, and appealed to SCs and Muslims by repeated references to Ambedkar and declaring Prophet Mohammed's birthday a public holiday. But as events unfolded it became clear that what Singh was trying to reap was a harvest of shame. He had been reduced to a vote-hungry power broker using the two elements that have bloodied and divided this nation—religion and caste.

Inderjit Badhwar, September 15, 1990,
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Obviously, his intended social engineering sites were minority ghettos and the heartlands of caste.

Mandal changed the syntax of Indian politics, and one politician's paranoia (Singh's social technology was essentially a defence mechanism against the rebellion of Devi Lal, who made the already dilapidated Janata Dal further vulnerable) made caste the last—and the lasting—arbiter of Indian politics. No political party showed the courage then to counter the caste agenda of the Mandal revolutionary. The expediencies of vote-bank politics triumphed over the idealism of meritocracy. With the constitutionally guaranteed reservation of 22.5 per cent for the Scheduled Castes and the Scheduled Tribes, India is already one of the most "reserved" nations on earth. In the beginning, it was meant to be a necessary corrective measure in an unequal society, though not as an eternal remedy. As India progressed in freedom, the politics of quota became blatant.

The spectre of Mandal has not stopped haunting. Even behind Modi's edition of electoral Ramayana, we can't miss the Mandal effect. For it was Mandal that provoked Advani's Somnath yatra, Hindutva's first road show, which would, eventually, have a historic finale in Delhi. Mandal, most definitively, set the stage for so many variations of social therapy. We saw another desperate politician playing out the script of Mandal Modified to make him a bit more relevant in the UPA Government. For a while, Arjun Singh set the social and cultural agenda of this Government. Like the first Singh of India's social Balkanisation, he too played quota politics as if he was the chosen one to be the keeper of India's social conscience. It was part of his secular project, but his neo-Nehruvian ambition was a negation of Nehru's secular India where caste and communities were not exactly permanent commodities for appeasement.

The truth is: the political mind of India has been Mandalised beyond redemption. It repudiates the India whose biggest selling point is Manmohan Singh, the much rhapsodised guru of free market. The narrative of 21st century India has to be powered by merit, not by the medieval passions of caste and communities. The new India may continue to be toasted in Davos and breathlessly mythified by travellers of the "flat world", but it still needs slogans that can sway the shirtless in the badlands of caste. Or that is what our political class thinks. That is why in an India where the ghost of Mandal refuses to be exorcised by the marketplace, the caste of an idiot can defeat the merit of the intelligent. ■